

iFOG modulator design and optimization for maximizing scale factor control precision

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Index Terms—TODO artificial neural network (ANN), circuit parameter extraction, multistatic localization, nonradiative dielectric (NRD) waveguide, numerical calibration waveguide filter, optimal sensor placement, traveling wave antenna.

I. INTRODUCTION

iFOG (Interferometric Fibre Optic Gyroscope) concept is based on the Sagnac effect [1], discovered in 1913 [2]. Over the years, the design has been exercised multiple times. However, the limits which hold the development back are constantly pushed forward as technology evolves. This allows for better precision, miniaturized size, lower power consumption, etc. At the same time, the ever progressing industry finds new and more strict applications for the gyroscopes, setting the requirements bar even higher. Such a context makes the already existing designs being tested and optimized in every possible aspect. This applies equally to all the optical and electro-optic components, the electronics and the driving software. A crucial part of the control system of an iFOG is the modulator. In a closed-loop design [3] it is a vital element of the feedback loop. It directly affects the overall performance. It drives the optical circuit into a predefined state, in which the circuit's response can be demodulated and error signals determined. Modulator accuracy has critical impact on the resulting performance. This paper takes a closer look at the all-digital implementation of the modulator subsystem - in particular on its electronic architecture and the algorithm controlling it. Mathematical analysis is conducted to allow for pure-software optimization of algorithm's accuracy.

II. PRINCIPLE OF OPERATION - OPEN-LOOP CONFIGURATION

Light source of an iFOG generates a light beam, which is ideally split in 50/50 ratio. Each half enters a loop of relatively long fiber through each of its ends. The fiber length

L determines light transit time τ through it - Equation 1, where n is the refraction coefficient, affecting light speed in the medium.

$$\tau = \frac{L}{n \cdot c} \quad (1)$$

The halves go past each other and exit on the opposite ends of the fiber. The optical circuit is arranged, so that the two exiting beams interfere with each other and the resulting light intensity is measured by a detector. When the circuit stays at rest, the beams interfere with zero phase shift ($\Delta\phi = 0$), resulting in maximum intensity P_0 measured at the detector. However, when the loop rotates, the two halves travel paths of a slightly different length, resulting in non-zero phase shift. The relative phase shift at the interference point is rotation dependent and in this paper it is referred to as the Sagnac-induced phase shift

$$\Delta\phi_s = \frac{2\pi \cdot L \cdot D \cdot n}{\lambda \cdot c} \cdot \omega \quad (2)$$

where D - fiber loop diameter, ω - angular velocity, λ - wavelength.

This has been depicted in Figure 1. Both halves enter the loop at the *entry point*. After the transit time they exit through the same point - now an *exit point*. Because of the non-zero rotation, this point moves along the loop, effectively shrinking one path and extending the other. Path difference is relatively small, thus it is expressed as a phase difference in wavelength domain.

The formula in Equation 3, also presented in Figure 2, is the optical circuit response function [4]. It describes how the

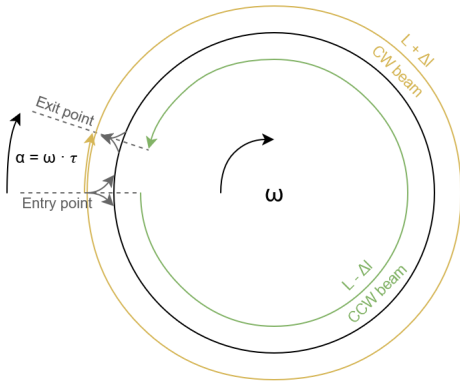


Fig. 1: Two counterpropagating light beam halves enter the fiber loop at the *Entry point*. Their phase is initially in sync. After transit time τ they exit and interfere. During that time the *Entry/Exit point* moves according to the rotation rate ω (by the angle $\alpha = \omega \cdot \tau$). As a result the CW and CCW halves cover non-equal path lengths ($L \pm \Delta l$), which leads to a non-zero phase difference.

measured light intensity depends on the total phase shift of the interfering light.

$$P(\Delta\phi) = \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + \cos(\Delta\phi)) \quad (3)$$

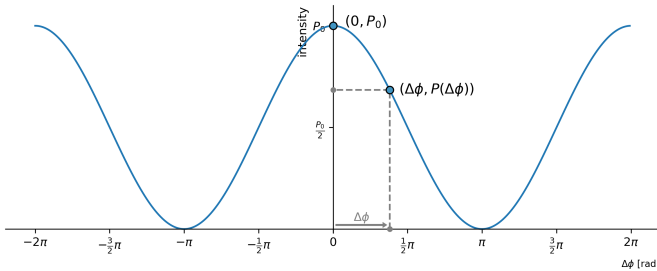


Fig. 2: Optical circuit response is an upshifted cosine. The two exemplary operating points refer to the circuit being at rest, yielding the maximum possible intensity in $(0, P_0)$ and a circuit subjected to rotation, at non-zero phase shift and decreased intensity in $(\Delta\phi, P(\Delta\phi))$.

When the circuit is at rest ($\omega = 0 \rightarrow \Delta\phi = 0$), the operating point resides at peak intensity P_0 . A non-zero rotation results in phase shift moving the operating point according to rotation rate and its direction, decreasing the measured intensity. Two problems are linked with this *open-loop* operation [5]. Firstly, intensity drop alone does not allow for determining rotation direction - response function is symmetrical. Secondly, in the resting region, the slope is flat, thus the sensitivity is zero. With greater rotation rate, the slope becomes more steep, reaching its maximum sensitivity in $\Delta\phi = \pm \frac{\pi}{2}$, but then decreases again. For these reasons a *closed-loop* configuration is superior in performance.

III. MODULATION SCHEME - CLOSED-LOOP CONFIGURATION

In a closed-loop configuration [5] the control system biases optical circuit sequentially in four predefined points $\Delta\phi \in \{\frac{3}{2}\pi, -\frac{1}{2}\pi, -\frac{3}{2}\pi, +\frac{1}{2}\pi\}$, utilizing the *four-step* modulation [6] (Figure 3). This allows for linearizing the response, keeping the circuit at maximum sensitivity and detecting rotation direction.

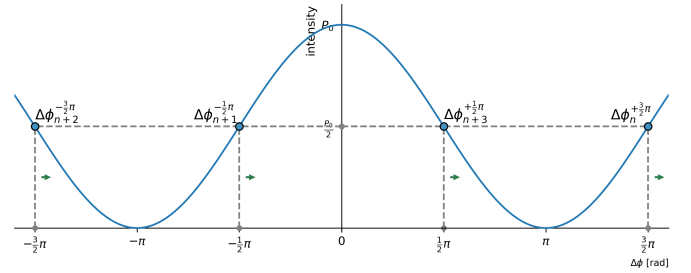
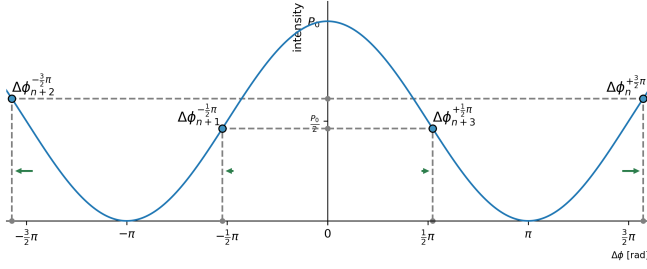


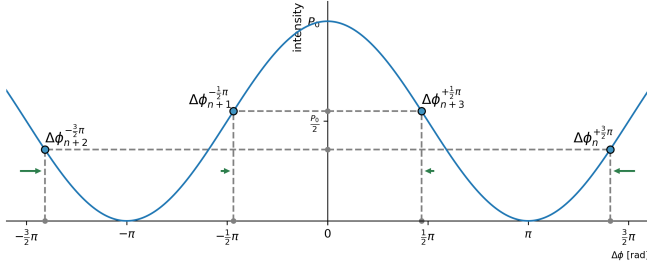
Fig. 3: Circuit biased in four points of highest sensitivity.

Compared to *two-step* modulation [6] this scheme is supreme, as it allows for controlling the *scale factor* - an essential parameter for maintaining device performance. Modulator injects the mentioned phase shifts by using an electro-optic actuator placed on the fiber path. The amount of applied shift is controlled by an electronic circuit. It performs digital calculations and generates corresponding voltages via a digital-to-analog converter and an electronic front-end. The voltage is translated to a phase shift according to the half-wave voltage V_π - a parameter of the actuator. Each element in this pipeline is subject to temperature drift and aging [7] effects, which influence the total combined gain. For this reason, continuous calibration is required for maintaining measurement accuracy and it is realized by tracking the scale factor. This allows the control algorithm to know where the desired bias points are in the digital domain, while they constantly drift.

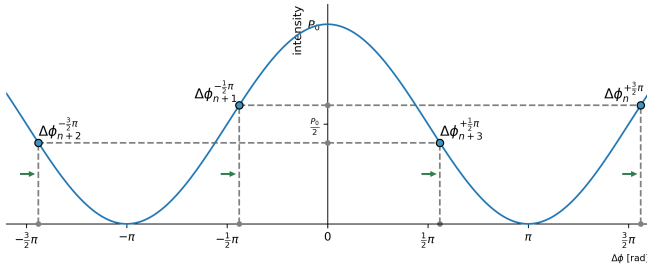
Diagrams in Figure 4 depict how the biased circuit responds to various conditions - i.e. misaligned scale factor and uncompensated rotation present. While this paper does not discuss in details how the rotation is measured, it is crucial to emphasize, that different feedback signals can be derived for scale factor adjustment and rotation measurement. These feedback signals allow the digital control loop for adjusting runtime parameters and placing the operating points exactly where they are intended to be.



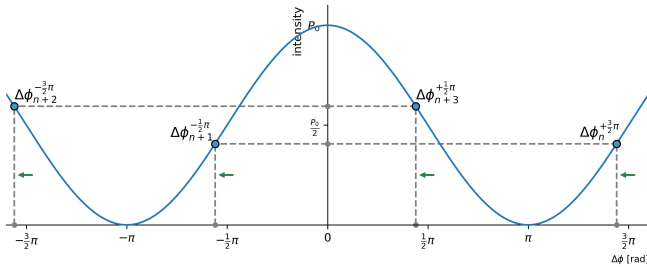
(a) Scale factor too high - bias points are shifted away from zero, resulting in intensity imbalance.



(b) Scale factor too low - bias points shifted towards zero, resulting in opposite imbalance.



(c) Phase shift induced by positive rotation - bias points shifted right. Points $\{4n, 4n + 1\}$ result in higher intensity than points $\{4n + 2, 4n + 3\}$.



(d) Phase shift induced by negative rotation - bias points shifted left. Points $\{4n, 4n + 1\}$ result in lower intensity than points $\{4n + 2, 4n + 3\}$.

Fig. 4: Four-step modulation allows for detection of scale factor error and uncompensated Sagnac-induced phase shift.

TODO FIX IN THE FIGURE $n+1 = 4n+1$ etc.

From control point of view and for simplicity, the combined scale factor can be referred to as the half-wave voltage V_π . Even though the actuator gain drift is only one of the scale factor components, the assumed linearity of others, makes it convenient to aggregate all into a single parameter. Other, non-linear errors, such as DAC INL are out of scope of this analysis. The control system uses the combined scale factor to bias the optical circuit continuously with the following bias

point order:

$$\begin{aligned} \{\Delta\phi_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{4}\pi} &\rightarrow (+\frac{3}{4}\pi), \\ \Delta\phi_{4n+1}^{-\frac{1}{4}\pi} &\rightarrow (-\frac{1}{4}\pi), \\ \Delta\phi_{4n+2}^{-\frac{3}{4}\pi} &\rightarrow (-\frac{3}{4}\pi), \\ \Delta\phi_{4n+3}^{+\frac{1}{4}\pi} &\rightarrow (+\frac{1}{4}\pi)\} \end{aligned} \quad (4)$$

where the superscripted phase is the intended effective phase shift for the given sample.

Modulator runs with the period of half the transit time $\frac{\tau}{2}$. This allows for the effective phase shift to be a result of a relative difference between every k 'th and $(k-2)$ 'th samples. In such case the phase shift applied by the modulator for each sample can be half of the desired amplitude, reducing the overall required voltage range [5]. Additionally, to null the effect of Sagnac-induced phase shift, modulator adds an ever-updating ramp signal, utilizing Serrodyne modulation [3] with the increment value of $\Delta\phi_r = -\Delta\phi_s$ - a phase shift of equal amplitude, but opposite sign. This way the algorithm nulls out the Sagnac-induced shift, while knowing how much of it it has cancelled, thus knowing the exact rotation rate. In every cycle, the software monitors both feedback signals and adjusts control accordingly.

IV. MODULATOR HARDWARE ARCHITECTURE

This paper opts in for an all-digital modulator architecture. Three distinct approaches can be distinguished:

- 1) fully-analog,
- 2) mixed - digital with analog front end,
- 3) all-digital.

Firstly - a fully analog variant (1), while feasible, does not comply with today's standards, where information is processed in a digital form. For integration with external systems, an analog-to-digital interface needs to be present anyway. In such case, incorporating an MCU or DSP in the processing loop brings the advantage of performing certain operations on pure data, rather than on signals carrying these data. A modern solution shall consist of a digital part for performing mathematical operations and electronic part for interfacing with the optical circuit - this resembles a classical - mixed - implementation (2). It consists of a DAC converter and a dedicated gain stage. Lastly, in a world of *software-defined* solutions [8], [9], an architecture with the minimum possible amount of electronic components can be tempting. The two latter concepts are described in this section. The all-analog architecture will not be discussed.

A. Dedicated gain stage

A reasonable tradeoff between analog and digital approaches is the architecture proposed in [5]. It is composed of a digital part - a DAC - and a dedicated analog gain stage. It has been depicted in Figure 5.

In this configuration DAC and PGA are driven with n - and m -bit words. The digital nature of controlling gain stage

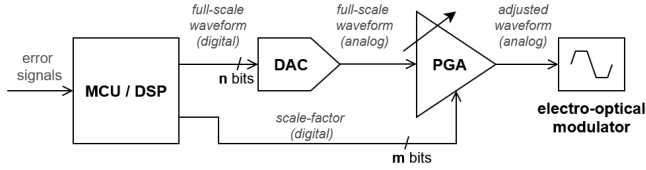


Fig. 5: Modulator with a dedicated analog gain stage. MCU/DSP outputs a fixed-scale digital waveform, which directly drives a DAC. Then, before reaching the electro-optic actuator, the scale factor is adjusted with a programmable gain amplifier (PGA), or a custom analog gain stage, resulting in adjusted-scale waveform.

introduces unavoidable quantization noise into the control loop. However, one of the important advantages of this setup is the intrinsic separation of the modulation problem into two smaller parts - generating the waveform in fixed-scale and applying the scale factor afterwards. The two can be implemented by software without dependence on each other, resulting in two distinct control loops. On the contrary, the dedicated gain stage is a subject to interferences. It may have its own nonlinearities and introduce delay in the signal path. Most importantly, its bandwidth may be gain dependent, distorting the waveform.

B. All-digital approach - software-defined solution

The all-digital approach depicted in Figure 6 utilizes the availability and wide range of high precision digital-to-analog converters. It allows for disposing the physical gain stage, by applying scale factor digitally, prior to driving the DAC. This requires DAC reference voltage to be high enough to cover all possible ranges. This approach also introduces quantization noise. These two disadvantages, are similarly the problems of the previous solution. The main advantage this idea brings is the minimization of the amount of electronic components used. This yields less sources of potential nonlinearities and electromagnetic interference. Since the electro-optic modulator has high input impedance, the output of a voltage-DAC can be directly connected to it, omitting any buffers on the signal path. The profit resulting from less noisy electronics copensate the unavoidable DAC resolution loss - its full range may never be utilized because of the required margins. Moreover, the following sections discusses an algorithmic approach, which regains one bit of accuracy, when using the all-digital architecture.

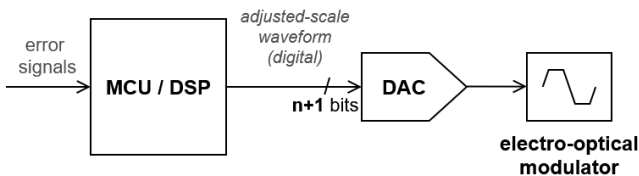


Fig. 6: All-digital modulator consists of minimal number of electronic components. In some cases this can simply be a DAC alone.

Additional advantage of leaning towards the proposed architecture is, that the whole design becomes a software-defined solution. As in other fields, it brings flexibility from the R&D process perspective. This is mainly because, while iterating hardware design is a time-consuming process, updating software is relatively quick and cost effective. Moving the problem completely to the software side obviously makes the implementation more complex, but at the same time it limits the amount of interaction at the boundary of software and hardware development, significantly reducing overhead. From this perspective the net workload remains relatively stable, offering slightly different - more modern - approach.

1) Voltage reference: For the all-digital modulator an adequate reference voltage has to be set up to account for the maximum possible scale factor in the devices lifetime. From Equation 4 it results, that a span of 1.5π is required for biasing and additionally, the Serrodyne modulator requires a span of 2π . This yields a required span of $S = 3.5\pi$. Minimum DAC reference V_{ref}^{min} shall account for it with some margin $M \in [1.0; 1.1]$:

$$V_{ref}^{min} = V_{\pi}^{max} \cdot S \cdot M \quad (5)$$

The V_{π}^{max} denotes the highest expected half-wave voltage. When determining final reference voltage it is advantageous to round it up to a multiple of one of typically available chip references (Equation 6), e.g. $K \times 5V$ or $K \times 4.096V$. It makes implementing the electronic circuit more straightforward. In practice, a fair compromise is to utilize the resulting voltage excess for the margin M , so that after adding it, the $V_{ref} \approx V_{ref}^{min}$.

$$V_{ref} = \lceil V_{ref}^{min} \rceil \quad (6)$$

2) Control accuracy and quantization error: Usage of a DAC results in quantization error. Converter resolution N and its reference voltage determine the minimal controllable voltage change as

$$\Delta v = V_{ref} \cdot 2^{-N} \quad (7)$$

In phase domain the scale factor can be thus controlled with the accuracy corresponding to Δv relative to the actual scale factor:

$$\Delta \phi_v = \frac{\Delta v}{V_{\pi}} \quad (8)$$

Due to the linear scale-factor dependence it will slowly vary over time, but its magnitude shall remain stable, as the drift is expected to only be at the level of percents. By substituting previous formulas, the final control accuracy and quantization error are:

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta \phi_v &= \frac{\lceil V_{\pi}^{max} \cdot S \cdot M \rceil \cdot 2^{-N}}{V_{\pi}} \\ \Delta \phi_q &= \frac{1}{2} \cdot \Delta \phi_v \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

Exemplary calculation, based on real-world values yields:

$$\begin{aligned}
\Delta\phi_v^{\text{ex}} &= \frac{\overbrace{[4.5V \cdot 3.5 \cdot 1.025]}^{V_\pi^{\text{max}} \cdot S \cdot M} \cdot \overbrace{2^{-16}}^{2^{-N}}}{\underbrace{3.5V}_{V_\pi}} = \\
&= \frac{[16.14V] \cdot 2^{-16}}{3.5V} = \frac{\overbrace{16.384V}^{4 \cdot 4.096V} \cdot 2^{-16}}{3.5V} = \\
&= 2^{-16} \cdot 4.68 = 2^{-16} \cdot 2^{2.23} \\
\Delta\phi_q^{\text{ex}} &= \frac{1}{2} \cdot \Delta\phi_v^{\text{ex}} = 2^{-16} \cdot 2^{1.23}
\end{aligned} \tag{10}$$

From this it is clear, that the quantization error, bound to controllable resolution can be improved by selecting a converter with greater number of bits. However, any selected resolution will always be a subject to losing just over two bits. It must be noted, that most of this loss is due to the span S , required for proper operation of the algorithm. It is not a consequence of using the proposed all-digital architecture. The quantization error follows the achieved accuracy. In each of the bias points, the following drive levels are possible:

$$\begin{aligned}
\phi_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{2}\pi} &= k_{4n+0} \cdot \Delta\phi_v = +\frac{3}{4}\pi + \delta_{4n+0} \\
\phi_{4n+0}^{-\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= k_{4n+1} \cdot \Delta\phi_v = -\frac{1}{4}\pi - \delta_{4n+1} \\
\phi_{4n+0}^{-\frac{3}{2}\pi} &= k_{4n+2} \cdot \Delta\phi_v = -\frac{3}{4}\pi - \delta_{4n+2} \\
\phi_{4n+0}^{+\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= k_{4n+3} \cdot \Delta\phi_v = +\frac{1}{4}\pi + \delta_{4n+3}
\end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

Value $k \in [-2^{N-1}, 2^{N-1} - 1]$ is an integer, in range of the used DAC (of N resolution). By incrementing/decrementing k_n the error δ_n can be controlled with the resolution of $\Delta\phi_v$. However, because of the quantization error, its value can always be up to $\Delta\phi_q$.

V. PRECISION ESTIMATION AND IMPACT

To close the scale factor control loop, a feedback is required. It is calculated from the difference of incident light intensity between two consecutive bias points. The total phase difference $\Delta\phi_k$, affecting intensity for the sample k , results from the current drive ϕ_k and the drive two points prior:

$$\Delta\phi_n = (\phi_n - \phi_{n-2}) + \underbrace{\Delta\phi_{s,n} + \Delta\phi_{r,n}}_{=0} \tag{12}$$

The values of $\Delta\phi_{s,n}$ and $\Delta\phi_{r,n}$ denote Sagnac-induced and nulling ramp shifts - assumed to be zero for this analysis. By using equations 3 and 4 and assuming the $\cos$ function linear near the bias points (Equation 14), intensity values at each point are:

$$\begin{aligned}
P_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{2}\pi} &= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + \cos(\Delta\phi_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{2}\pi})) = \\
&= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + \cos(\underbrace{\phi_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{2}\pi}}_{\frac{3}{4}\pi + \delta_{4n+0}} - \underbrace{\phi_{4n-2}^{-\frac{3}{2}\pi}}_{-(\frac{3}{4}\pi + \delta_{4n-2})})) = \\
&= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + \cos(\frac{3}{2}\pi + \delta_{4n+0} + \delta_{4n-2})) = \\
&= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + (\delta_{4n+0} + \delta_{4n-2}))
\end{aligned} \tag{13}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
P_{4n+1}^{-\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 - (\delta_{4n+1} + \delta_{4n-1})) \\
P_{4n+2}^{-\frac{3}{2}\pi} &= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 + (\delta_{4n+2} + \delta_{4n+0})) \\
P_{4n+3}^{+\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= \frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (1 - (\delta_{4n+3} + \delta_{4n+1}))
\end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
\cos(\phi_b + \Delta\phi) &= \underbrace{\cos(\phi_b)}_{=0} + \cos'(\phi_b) \cdot \Delta\phi = \\
&= -\sin(\phi_b) \cdot \Delta\phi \\
\text{for } \phi_b &\in \{+\frac{3}{2}\pi, +\frac{1}{2}\pi, -\frac{1}{2}\pi, -\frac{3}{2}\pi\}
\end{aligned} \tag{14}$$

Feedback signal calculated at samples $4n+1$ and $4n+3$ is:

$$\begin{aligned}
e_{4n+1}^{-\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= P_{4n+1}^{-\frac{1}{2}\pi} - P_{4n+0}^{+\frac{3}{2}\pi} = \\
&= -\frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (\delta_{4n+1} + \delta_{4n+0} + \delta_{4n-1} + \delta_{4n-2}) \\
e_{4n+3}^{+\frac{1}{2}\pi} &= P_{4n+3}^{+\frac{1}{2}\pi} - P_{4n+2}^{-\frac{3}{2}\pi} = \\
&= -\frac{P_0}{2} \cdot (\delta_{4n+3} + \delta_{4n+2} + \delta_{4n+1} + \delta_{4n+0})
\end{aligned} \tag{15}$$

It can be generalized for every odd bias sample, where it shall be calculated - this results from the demodulation algorithm assumptions [5]:

$$e_{2n+1} = -\frac{P_0}{2} \cdot \underbrace{(\delta_{2n+1})}_{\text{current}} + \underbrace{(\delta_{2n+0} + \delta_{2n-1} + \delta_{2n-2})}_{\text{three previous errors}} \tag{16}$$

The feedback signal, used for loop closure, is dependent on four recent drive values. Because the DAC can be controlled with Δv resolution, the scale factor error, and thus the occurring errors δ_n are all controllable with a fixed delta $\Delta\phi_v$ corresponding to Δv . In particular the presented error sum for the last four samples can be controlled with $\Delta\phi_v$ accuracy, but this may only happen when the current sample accounts for the three previous ones.

VI. ALGORITHM DESIGN

From the derived error equation a few important results can be determined. Firstly, the most likely mistakes are emphasized in the following subsection. Secondly, a correct modulator implementation is presented in pseudocode.

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